Module 6, Lesson 4: Automation Consulting

The Highest Value Model

Consulting delivers the highest income per hour of any zero-cost business model. You're not selling products or content—you're selling your expertise, strategic thinking, and problem-solving abilities.

Businesses are desperate for guidance on AI automation. They know they need it, they don't know how to do it, and they're willing to pay well for someone who can help them figure it out.

What Automation Consultants Do

Assessment and Strategy

What It Is: Evaluate a business's current processes, identify automation opportunities, and create a roadmap for implementation.

Deliverables:

- Process audit report
- Automation opportunity assessment
- ROI projections
- Implementation roadmap
- Tool recommendations

Pricing: $1,500-$10,000 per engagement

Time Required: 5-20 hours

Implementation Guidance

What It Is: Guide a business through the implementation of automation, providing expertise while their team does the work.

Deliverables:

- Implementation plan
- Weekly guidance calls
- Troubleshooting support
- Progress reviews
- Optimization recommendations

Pricing: $200-500$/hour or $3,000-10,000$/month retainer

Time Required: 5-15 hours/week

Done-With-You Implementation

What It Is: Work alongside the business's team to implement automation, teaching while doing.

Deliverables:

- Hands-on implementation
- Team training
- Documentation
- Knowledge transfer
- Ongoing support

Pricing: $5,000-25,000$ per project

Time Required: 20-60 hours

Training and Workshops

What It Is: Teach teams how to implement and manage their own automation.

Deliverables:

- Workshop curriculum
- Training sessions
- Hands-on exercises
- Reference materials
- Follow-up support

Pricing: $2,000-10,000$ per workshop or $500-2,000$/hour for training

Time Required: 4-16 hours per workshop

Positioning Yourself as a Consultant

Define Your Niche

Don't be a general "AI consultant." Be specific:

Too Broad: "I help businesses with AI automation."

Better: "I help small businesses automate their operations."

Best: "I help 10-50 person professional service firms automate client onboarding and reduce administrative time by 40%."

The more specific, the easier to:

- Target marketing
- Command premium pricing
- Develop expertise
- Generate referrals

Possible Niches

By Industry:

- Real estate agencies
- Law firms
- Accounting firms

- Marketing agencies
- Healthcare practices
- E-commerce businesses
- Manufacturing companies

By Function:

- Client onboarding
- Sales and CRM
- Marketing automation
- Operations streamlining
- Customer service automation
- Financial processes

By Size:

- Solopreneurs
- Small businesses (5-20 people)
- Growing businesses (20-100 people)
- Mid-size companies (100-500 people)

Develop Your Methodology

Create a repeatable process that delivers results:

Example: The Automation Roadmap Method

1. **Discovery (Week 1)**
    - Stakeholder interviews
    - Process documentation
    - Pain point identification
    - Quick win identification
2. **Assessment (Week 2)**
    - Current state analysis

    - Automation opportunity scoring
    - ROI calculations
    - Tool evaluation

3. **Strategy (Week 3)**
    - Roadmap development
    - Priority recommendations
    - Implementation timeline
    - Resource requirements

4. **Presentation (Week 4)**
    - Executive presentation
    - Documentation delivery
    - Q&A session
    - Next steps discussion

A methodology makes you look professional, ensures consistent results, and justifies your pricing.

Build Your Authority

Before you have clients:

- Create content demonstrating expertise
- Document your own automation journey
- Share case studies (even your own)
- Speak at local business events
- Offer free workshops to groups

As you get clients:

- Get testimonials
- Write case studies
- Share results (with permission)

- Encourage referrals
- Build a portfolio

The Consulting Sales Process

Lead Generation

Where clients come from:

Network:

- Professional connections
- Previous colleagues
- Industry associations
- Local business groups

Content:

- Blog posts on automation
- LinkedIn content
- Speaking engagements
- Podcast appearances

Referrals:

- Ask satisfied clients
- Partner with complementary services
- Incentivize referrals
- Make referrals easy

Partnerships:

- Software companies (implementation partners)
- Business coaches (add-on service)
- IT providers (specialization)

- Marketing agencies (operations support)

Qualification

Not every lead is a good client. Qualify them:

Good Fit:

- Has budget for consulting
- Understands the value
- Ready to take action
- Decision-maker involved
- Realistic expectations

Bad Fit:

- Wants everything for free
- Doesn't see the value
- Not ready to implement
- Can't make decisions
- Expects overnight transformation

Qualification Questions:

- "What's your timeline for implementing automation?"
- "What budget have you allocated for this?"
- "Who will be involved in the decision?"
- "What have you tried before?"
- "What would success look like?"

The Discovery Call

Goal: Understand their needs and determine fit.

Structure:

1. **Rapport (5 min)**

    - Introduction
    - How they found you
    - What prompted the call

2. **Exploration (15-20 min)**
    - Current situation
    - Pain points
    - Goals and timeline
    - Previous attempts
    - Budget and resources

3. **Value Preview (5 min)**
    - Share relevant insights
    - Mention similar situations
    - Preview how you'd help

4. **Next Steps (5 min)**
    - Propose the engagement
    - Explain your process
    - Discuss investment
    - Schedule follow-up

Key Insight: The discovery call is not about selling—it's about understanding and qualifying. If there's a fit, selling happens naturally.

The Proposal

Structure:

1. **Executive Summary**
    - Their situation in your words
    - The opportunity you see
    - Your recommendation

2. **Current State**
    - What you observed
    - Pain points identified
    - Opportunities spotted
3. **Proposed Solution**
    - Your methodology
    - Specific activities
    - Timeline
    - Deliverables
4. **Expected Outcomes**
    - Time savings projected
    - Cost savings projected
    - Efficiency improvements
    - ROI calculation
5. **Investment**
    - Fee structure
    - Payment terms
    - What's included
6. **Next Steps**
    - How to proceed
    - Timeline for decision
    - Contact information

Pricing Psychology:

- Present one option (easier decision)
- Or three options (give choice, anchor high)
- Include ROI justification

- Be confident in your pricing

Closing

Natural Close: If the proposal is right for them, closing should be natural:

"Based on what we discussed, I recommend the Assessment and Roadmap engagement. That's $5,000, and we can start next week. Does that work for you?"

Objection Handling:

"It's too expensive." "I understand budget is a concern. Let's look at the ROI. Based on what you've told me, you're spending X hours per week on [manual process]. At your hourly rate, that's $Y per month. This system will save most of that time, paying for itself in Z months. After that, it's all profit. Would it help to see those numbers broken down?"

"I need to think about it." "Of course. What specific questions do you have? I want to make sure you have all the information you need to make the right decision."

"I need to talk to my partner." "Absolutely. Would it be helpful if we scheduled a brief call with them? I could answer any questions they have."

"Can you do it for less?" "I appreciate you asking. The investment reflects the value and results you'll receive. What I can do is break it into phases so you can see results before committing to the full engagement. Would that help?"

Delivery Excellence

Setting Expectations

At project start:

- Confirm scope and deliverables
- Agree on timeline
- Establish communication cadence
- Define success metrics
- Clarify roles and responsibilities

Communication Rhythm

Weekly:

- Status update
- Progress report
- Next steps
- Questions/blockers

Milestone:

- Deliverable presentation
- Feedback session
- Adjustments needed
- Next phase planning

As Needed:

- Urgent issues
- Quick questions
- Celebrating wins

Delivering Value

Underpromise, Overdeliver:

- Set realistic expectations
- Exceed them when possible
- Surprise with extra value
- Document everything

Create Artifacts:

- Clear documentation
- Visual presentations
- Executive summaries

- Implementation guides

Teach, Don't Just Do:

- Explain your thinking
- Build their capability
- Create independence
- Add lasting value

Getting Results

Track Metrics:

- Time saved
- Errors reduced
- Efficiency gained
- ROI achieved

Document Success:

- Before/after comparisons
- Specific examples
- Testimonial opportunities
- Case study material

Pricing Your Services

Hourly vs. Project vs. Retainer

Hourly:

- Good for: Uncertain scope, ongoing advisory
- Range: 150−500/hour
- Pros: Simple, flexible
- Cons: Caps income, penalizes efficiency

Project:

- Good for: Defined scope, clear deliverables
- Range: $2,000-25,000$/project
- Pros: Value-based, predictable
- Cons: Scope creep risk, requires clarity

Retainer:

- Good for: Ongoing relationships, advisory
- Range: $2,000-10,000$/month
- Pros: Predictable income, deeper relationships
- Cons: Can become undervalued, requires management

Recommended Approach

Start with project pricing:

- Easier to sell
- Clear deliverables
- Build portfolio

Move to retainers:

- After successful projects
- For ongoing relationships
- Creates predictable income

Hourly only for:

- Uncertain scope
- Quick consultations
- Existing relationships

Value-Based Pricing

Price based on the value you create, not the time you spend:

Example: A client spends 20 hours/week on manual processes. Their time is worth $100/hour.That's$2,000/week or $8,000/month in labor cost.

If you can automate 50% of that: You save them $4,000/monthor$48,000/year.

A $10,000 engagement that delivers this has a 5x ROI in year one.

This is why automation consulting commands premium prices—the value is clear and substantial.

Growing Your Consulting Business

Phase 1: Foundation (Month 1-6)

Focus:

- Get first 3-5 clients
- Develop methodology
- Build portfolio
- Get testimonials

Revenue:

- $3,000-$10,000/month

Activities:

- Network actively
- Create content
- Offer free consultations
- Deliver excellent work

Phase 2: Growth (Month 6-18)

Focus:

- Increase pricing
- Specialize further

- Build systems
- Get referrals

Revenue:

- $10,000-$25,000/month

Activities:

- Raise prices
- Narrow niche
- Systematize delivery
- Create case studies

Phase 3: Scale (Month 18+)

Focus:

- Build team
- Create products
- Increase impact
- Reduce hours

Revenue:

- $25,000-$50,000+/month

Activities:

- Hire contractors/employees
- Create products
- Delegate delivery
- Focus on sales/strategy

The Oliver Agency Partnership

For clients who need more than consulting—full implementation, enterprise solutions, or comprehensive digital transformation—The Oliver Agency offers the depth to serve them. Your consulting identifies opportunities; The Oliver Agency can deliver the complete solution.

Coming Up Next

In Lesson 6.5, we'll explore Scaling Without Spending—how to grow your AI automation business without requiring significant capital investment.

Key Takeaways

1. **Consulting commands premium prices** - Value-based pricing justifies high fees
2. **Niche specificity wins** - The more specific, the easier to position and price
3. **Methodology creates consistency** - A repeatable process delivers reliable results
4. **Price based on value, not time** - ROI justifies your investment
5. **Deliver excellence, ask for referrals** - Great work leads to more great work